THE SWORN BACHELORS · PART TWO

The Ruthless Director Who Never Forgave Betrayal Fell for the Woman Who Betrayed Him

Michael × Sophia

He fires superstars for being twenty minutes late. He has never forgiven a single person. Then a fisherman's daughter walks into his office, sits in his chair and tells him he is in her story.

MICHAEL
Ruthless. Ambitious. Hiding her.

SOPHIA
Proud. Betrayed. Betrays him back.

SOMEONE CLOSE
Is destroying them both

30	~25	7	100%
SCENES	MINUTES	TWISTS TO GUESS	DIALOGUE

The cast

MICHAEL McCLAREN
(37). Nigeria's most powerful film director and owner of McClaren Studios. Charming in public and ruthless on set. Since he joined his studio to his brothers' money, he has had more to lose and less mercy. His rule: *"Betray me once and you're dead to me."*

DONALD IRWIN
(37). Michael's brother from Part One. Controlling, suspicious, and secretly in love with Emma.

KOLA BADMUS
(40). Michael's executive producer and right-hand man for fifteen years, since the days of filming weddings in Enugu.

DAPO
(28). Nigeria's most popular actor.

MR. HARGREAVES
Head of a foreign streaming platform, seen on a video call.

WAITER

SOPHIA BENNETT
(31). Screenwriter from Badagry, a fisherman's daughter. She is proud and fearless, and allergic to his ambition. She wrote *The Last Horizon* about her father, who went to sea and never came back.

GEOFFREY DUROSE
(37). Michael's brother. Quiet and watchful, and hiding a file about his father.

MAMA BENNETT
(60). Sophia's mother, a fisherman's widow.

BISI
Assistant director.

VICTOR ADEKUNLE
CEO of Apex Studios, Michael's biggest rival. Heard only on the phone.

Meanwhile, in Part One...

Part Two happens at the same time as Part One. Here is what Michael was really doing during the scenes you have already seen.

PART ONE · SCENE 13

Donald calls Michael "asking for a friend" → Sophia was waiting behind Michael's trailer

PART ONE · SCENE 17

Rooftop Night, "Who's Script Supervisor?" → Sophia had just told Michael she loved him

PART ONE · SCENE 22

the jollof, the shoe, "Sophia." / "Adaeze." → Michael races home to tell Sophia that Donald is hiding a woman

PART ONE · SCENE 36

"Not now, Michael." → He was about to confess. Sophia was calling about their last-chance date

PART ONE · SCENE 45

"You promised you'd tell them tonight." → He breaks Sophia's heart one more time, then fixes everything

How to enjoy this PDF

- Tap any scene in the contents to jump straight to it. Your PDF app's bookmarks list every scene too.
- At 7 cliffhangers there is a **Guess the twist** box. Tick your answer (the boxes are real checkboxes in most PDF apps), then keep reading.
- When a twist is revealed, a green box links back to your guess. All answers are on the last page.
- `PART ONE LINK` marks scenes you saw in Part One, now from Michael's side. `SECRET` marks scenes where Michael is hiding Sophia.

Scenes

01	"Yes. I Did It."		0:00
02	"Cut."		0:35
03	Three Brothers, No Trust		1:30
04	The Woman who Wasn't Impressed		2:31
05	The Fisherman's Daughter		3:50
06	He Forgot to Say "Action"		4:36
07	The Man who Never Forgives	GUESS ★	5:04
08	"Asking For a Friend" PART ONE LINK SECRET		6:09
09	The First Empty Chair		7:04
10	The Deal	GUESS ★	7:20
11	"It Was My Birthday"		7:46
12	"Still Sworn" PART ONE LINK SECRET		8:43
13	The Shoe PART ONE LINK SECRET		9:26
14	The Rules SECRET	GUESS ★	10:18
15	The Worst Actor in Nigeria SECRET		10:52
16	The Brothers Explode SECRET		11:33
17	The Email She Wasn't Supposed to See	GUESS ★	12:41
18	"Dead to Me"		13:05
19	He Can't Delete Her		14:11
20	"I Still Love Him"		14:31
21	The Sabotage Gets Worse	GUESS ★	15:13
22	3 A.m., in the Rain		15:57
23	"Not Now, Michael" PART ONE LINK SECRET		17:01
24	The Second Empty Chair		17:30
25	"When Is It Me?"	GUESS ★	17:43
26	"Someone Sitting Close to You"		18:33
27	The Third Brother		19:33
28	The Last Lie on the Rooftop PART ONE LINK SECRET		20:53
29	The Premiere	GUESS ★	21:54
30	Two Down		23:32
★	Answer key and your detective score		

SCENE 1 OF 30 · 0:00–0:35

"Yes. I Did It."

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — MICHAEL'S OFFICE — NIGHT — RAIN ON THE WINDOWS

MICHAEL McCLAREN stands with a printed email shaking in his hand. Every blog in Lagos is on his wall of screens: "McCLAREN STOLE A DEAD FISHERMAN'S STORY." SOPHIA BENNETT stands across the desk, soaked and not backing down.

MICHAEL These emails came from MY laptop. At 1 a.m. In MY office. *(quietly)* Only one person was here at 1 a.m., Sophia.

SOPHIA Yes. I did it.

MICHAEL *(as if she slapped him)* Do you know what I do to people who betray me?

SOPHIA You ruin them. Everybody in Lagos knows.

MICHAEL Then why are you still standing in my office?

SOPHIA *(stepping closer)* Because you haven't ruined me yet, Michael. *(beat)* Why not?

Thunder. Michael opens his mouth, but nothing comes out.

MICHAEL *(barely a whisper)* ...I don't know.

FOUR MONTHS EARLIER

↑ All scenes

SCENE 2 OF 30 · 0:35–1:30

"Cut."

EXT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — FILM SET OF "THE LAST HORIZON" — BADAGRY BEACH — DAY

> *A huge beach set with cameras, a crane, a hundred crew and an old wooden fishing boat. Michael sits in his director's chair in dark glasses. DAPO, the superstar actor, strolls in with his entourage twenty minutes late.*

DAPO Sorry, Oga Michael. Traffic.

MICHAEL *(not looking up)* Bisi. What time did we call Dapo?

BISI Six a.m., sir.

MICHAEL And what time is it?

BISI Six twenty-one, sir.

MICHAEL *(standing, removing the glasses)* A hundred people were standing in the sun for twenty-one minutes. A hundred people who also have traffic. *(to Dapo)* You're fired.

DAPO *(laughing)* You can't fire me. I'm Dapo.

MICHAEL And tomorrow, you'll be the actor who used to be Dapo. Security.

> *Gasps. KOLA BADMUS, Michael's producer, hurries over.*

KOLA *(whispering)* Michael, he has eleven million followers. The investors—

MICHAEL The investors are my brothers, Kola. I'll handle my brothers. *(loud, to the crew)* Recast by Monday! *(He sits.)* And Kola, the screenplay. Did the writer sign the changes?

KOLA She refused. She's in your office right now.

MICHAEL Then she can wait.

KOLA Sir… she's been waiting since five.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 3 OF 30 · 1:30–2:31

Three Brothers, No Trust

INT. THREE BOYS VENTURES — PRIVATE BOARDROOM, IKOYI — DAY

A long table, three chairs, three closed laptops. DONALD sits at the head as always, with GEOFFREY on the right. Michael walks in late and sits with his feet on the table.

DONALD The Last Horizon. Your budget has tripled, Michael. Six billion naira. I want the breakdown.

MICHAEL No.

DONALD We merged so we could stop hiding things from each other.

MICHAEL Then you go first. Geoffrey moved money last month. Who did he move it to?

Geoffrey adjusts his glasses and says nothing.

DONALD Geoffrey?

GEOFFREY *(calm)* It's handled.

MICHAEL *(throwing up his hands)* You see? Everybody has a secret except me, and I'm the one being audited!

DONALD You fired Dapo this morning. It's on every blog. That's eleven million followers who won't buy a ticket.

MICHAEL I've built my career on firing people who waste my time, Donald. That's what you two paid for.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* We paid for a brother. Lately we're getting a stranger.

Silence. Michael stands and buttons his jacket.

MICHAEL I have a writer to deal with.

DONALD "Deal with"?

MICHAEL She's suing my studio. I'll crush her by lunch.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 4 OF 30 · 2:31–3:50

The Woman who Wasn't Impressed

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — MICHAEL'S OFFICE — DAY

Posters of his blockbuster films line the walls, with awards on shelves. Sophia sits in HIS chair behind HIS desk, reading her own screenplay, which has his red pen all over it. Michael walks in and stops.

MICHAEL You're in my chair.

SOPHIA You're in my story.

He blinks. Nobody talks to him like this.

MICHAEL Miss Bennett, I'm a busy man—

SOPHIA I know. I've been watching you be busy for six hours. *(She holds up the script.)* Page ninety-two. In my story, the fisherman goes to sea and never comes back. His wife stands on the beach every evening until the sun disappears. That's the last horizon. *(beat)* In YOUR version, he comes back with a boat full of gold and buys a mansion in Lekki.

MICHAEL People don't pay to cry, Miss Bennett. They pay to hope.

SOPHIA My father didn't come back with gold. He didn't come back at all. *(She stands.)* You can't make his death a happy ending because it sells better.

MICHAEL *(smiling, smooth)* Name your price. Fifty million. A hundred. You'll never write another word in your life.

SOPHIA *(walking right up to him)* That's the problem with men like you. You think everything has a price because everything you love does.

She drops the script on his chest and walks to the door.

SOPHIA My lawyer will call your lawyer. Have a nice day, Mr. Director.

The door closes. Michael stands frozen, still holding the script against his chest. Kola peeks in.

KOLA Should I call legal?

MICHAEL *(still staring at the door)* No.

KOLA Sir?

MICHAEL Call her back. *(beat)* Hire her.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 5 OF 30 · 3:50–4:36

The Fisherman's Daughter

INT. MAMA BENNETT'S SMALL HOUSE, BADAGRY — EVENING

A tiny, neat sitting room. An old photo of a smiling fisherman hangs on the wall. MAMA BENNETT fries fish. Sophia waves a letter.

SOPHIA He wants to hire me, Mama! Co-writer on set. Every day. With HIM.

MAMA BENNETT The man who stole your story?

SOPHIA The most arrogant man in Nigeria. He fired an actor for being twenty minutes late.

MAMA BENNETT *(turning the fish)* Your father was never late for the sea. Not one day. *(beat)* He was only late for us.

Sophia goes quiet. She looks at the photo.

SOPHIA That's exactly why I can't stand him. He's married to his work, like Papa was married to the sea.

MAMA BENNETT Then go and take your story back from him. *(beat)* And don't fall into his sea, my daughter.

SOPHIA *(laughing)* Mama. Please. Never.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 6 OF 30 · 4:36–5:04

He Forgot to Say "Action"

EXT. THE LAST HORIZON SET — BADAGRY BEACH — DAY

The cameras are rolling and the crew is ready. Michael sits in his chair, and Sophia sits on a crate beside him with a notebook. The new lead actor waits in the boat.

BISI Sir, we're ready.

Michael is watching Sophia, who is mouthing the lines along with the actor and wiping a tear.

BISI Sir? …Sir! Everyone is waiting for "Action."

MICHAEL *(snapping back)* Cut!

BISI Sir, we haven't started.

MICHAEL Then… action! Action. Yes. Action.

Sophia raises an eyebrow. Kola, behind them, notices everything and keeps his face blank.

SOPHIA *(whispering)* The great Michael McClaren forgot how to start a scene?

MICHAEL *(whispering back)* The great Michael McClaren was thinking about the ending.

SOPHIA My ending?

MICHAEL *(after a beat)* …I haven't decided whose ending yet.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 7 OF 30 · 5:04–6:09

The Man who Never Forgives

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — EDITING SUITE — 2 AM

Only the screens light the dark room. Michael and Sophia sit close, watching rough footage of the fishing boat sailing into the sunset. Takeaway jollof containers are on the desk.

SOPHIA Why are you like this? Everyone on that set is afraid of you.

MICHAEL Good. Afraid people don't steal.

SOPHIA Who stole from you?

A long silence. He pauses the footage.

MICHAEL My first film. Enugu. I was twenty-two. My producer, Chuka, my best friend in that city, took the master tape to Lagos and released it under his own name. *(beat)* Then my fiancée left me for a man with a yacht.

SOPHIA And?

MICHAEL And I spent five years buying every company Chuka worked for and firing him from each one. *(He smiles, but there's no warmth in it.)* He sells phones in Alaba now. *(beat)* I never forgive, Sophia. Not once. Not anybody.

SOPHIA *(softly)* That's not strength, Michael. That's a scar you're proud of.

He turns to look at her. They're very close. Neither moves away.

MICHAEL You're the only person who talks to me like that.

SOPHIA You're the only person who needs it this badly.

He leans in. She leans in. The door bangs open.

KOLA Sir, the investors moved the call to— *(He stops.)* ...Sorry. Wrong time.

Kola backs out. His face is blank, but he looks at Sophia a second too long.

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

Someone in Michael's circle can't be trusted. Who?

- ☐ Sophia, the writer
- ☐ Kola, his producer of fifteen years
- ☐ Bisi, the assistant director
- ☐ Donald, his brother

Revealed in Scene 27 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 8 OF 30 · 6:09–7:04 PART ONE LINK SECRET

"Asking For a Friend"

INT. FILM SET — BEHIND A TRAILER — NIGHT

> *Michael is on the phone, grinning. Sophia waits beside the trailer, holding his jacket. (This is Part One, Scene 13, seen from Michael's side.)*

DONALD (ON PHONE) If a man can't stop thinking about… a report. Written by a person.

MICHAEL Donald. Is this "report" wearing heels?

DONALD (ON PHONE) Goodnight, Michael.

MICHAEL *(laughing into the dead line)* Donald! DONALD! Are you breaking the—

SOPHIA Michael, are you coming or not?

> *Michael spins around in panic and hisses at her.*

MICHAEL Sophia! I said wait in the car!

SOPHIA *(arms folded)* Why? Who was that?

MICHAEL My brother.

SOPHIA And your brother can't know I exist?

MICHAEL *(lowering his voice)* Sophia. Seven years ago, on a rooftop, my brothers and I swore that none of us would ever fall in love. Whoever breaks it first has to confess like a fool and give up his share of our first company.

SOPHIA *(slowly)* So I'm a secret.

MICHAEL You're not a secret. You're… a strategy.

SOPHIA *(handing him his jacket hard)* Then strategise your own way home.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 9 OF 30 · 7:04–7:20

The First Empty Chair

INT. CANDLELIT RESTAURANT, VICTORIA ISLAND — NIGHT

> *A beautiful table by the window. Sophia sits in a red dress, her phone face up beside a small cake with "Happy Birthday, Sophia" written on it. The chair opposite is empty. 8:00. 8:40. 9:30. A WAITER hovers.*

WAITER Madam, should we… still wait?

SOPHIA *(forcing a smile)* He's a director. He's always late. Just one more glass of water.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 10 OF 30 · 7:20–7:46

The Deal

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — CONFERENCE ROOM — SAME NIGHT — INTERCUT

> *Michael is on a giant video call with MR. HARGREAVES of a foreign streaming platform. His phone buzzes over and over on the table with "Script Supervisor." He turns it face down.*

MR. HARGREAVES (ON SCREEN) Michael, we're prepared to take The Last Horizon global. Two hundred countries. But we need the happy ending. Families don't subscribe to grief.

MICHAEL *(not even hesitating)* The happy ending stays. You have my word.

MR. HARGREAVES (ON SCREEN) And the writer? I hear she's difficult.

MICHAEL *(after a tiny pause)* The writer is handled.

> *The phone buzzes again. He doesn't turn it over. Kola, sitting beside him, sees the screen and says nothing.*

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

It's Sophia's birthday and she's waiting. Will Michael show up?

- ☐ Yes, on time
- ☐ Yes, three hours late and talking about a deal
- ☐ He never comes

Revealed in **Scene 11 →**

↑ All scenes

SCENE 11 OF 30 · 7:46–8:43

"It Was My Birthday"

EXT. RESTAURANT — VICTORIA ISLAND — 11:15 PM

> *Sophia walks out holding the uneaten cake. Michael's car screeches to the kerb. He jumps out with his tie loose, glowing with excitement.*

MICHAEL Sophia! I'm sorry, I'm sorry! But listen. Two hundred countries! The Last Horizon is going GLOBAL! Do you know what this means?

SOPHIA *(very calm)* Do you know what today means?

MICHAEL It means everything we— *(He sees the cake.)* "Happy Birthday, Sophia." *(The excitement drains out of him.)* ...Oh, God.

SOPHIA Three hours, Michael. And when you finally came, the first thing out of your mouth was a deal.

MICHAEL Sophia, I'll make it up to you. Tomorrow, I'll fly you anywhere. Dubai. Paris—

SOPHIA I don't want Paris! I want a man who remembers I exist when there's no camera on me!

> *She pushes the cake into his hands.*

SOPHIA My father missed every birthday I ever had because the sea was always more important. I swore I'd never love a man like that. *(Her voice breaks.)* And look at me.

> *She gets into a taxi. Michael stands on the pavement holding a birthday cake, the most powerful director in Nigeria and completely powerless.*

TWIST REVEALED · It's Sophia's birthday and she's waiting. Will Michael show up? The answer: **Yes, three hours late and talking about a deal**. See what you guessed in Scene 10 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 12 OF 30 · 8:43–9:26 PART ONE LINK SECRET

"Still Sworn"

EXT. AJEGUNLE ROOFTOP — ROOFTOP NIGHT — (PART ONE, SCENE 17)

> *Fairy lights and three leather chairs. Michael's phone keeps lighting up in his pocket with "Script Supervisor." He flips it face down.*

MICHAEL Still sworn?

GEOFFREY *(a tiny pause)* Still sworn.

DONALD Still sworn.

MICHAEL *(too loud)* Still sworn!

DONALD *(leaning in, aggressive)* Who's "Script Supervisor", Michael? She calls you eleven times a day.

MICHAEL She… supervises scripts.

DONALD At 2 a.m.?

MICHAEL Scripts don't sleep, Donald! And who's YOUR "report"? You blush when your phone buzzes!

DONALD That's business.

MICHAEL Business! Everything is "business" with you two! Geoffrey moves billions and says "it's handled"! You hide your phone like a teenager! And I'm the one on trial?

GEOFFREY *(standing, buttoning his jacket)* I have an early board meeting.

MICHAEL It's SATURDAY!

> *Geoffrey is gone. Donald and Michael stare at each other, two liars with nowhere left to go.*

DONALD *(quietly)* Rule four, Michael.

MICHAEL *(just as quietly)* Rule four, Donald.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 13 OF 30 · 9:26–10:18 PART ONE LINK SECRET

The Shoe

INT. MICHAEL'S G-WAGON — NIGHT — DRIVING (AFTER PART ONE, SCENE 22)

> *Michael drives with one hand, eating jollof from Donald's plate. A woman's size thirty-eight heel sits on the passenger seat. He's on speakerphone with Sophia, laughing hard.*

MICHAEL Sophia, listen! DONALD IRWIN is hiding a woman in his kitchen! I have her SHOE!

SOPHIA ON PHONE *(laughing despite herself)* The serious one? The one who schedules his lunch?

MICHAEL 12:07, every day! And tonight there were two plates of jollof!

SOPHIA ON PHONE So tell Geoffrey. Win your little rooftop game.

MICHAEL *(the laugh fading)* I can't.

SOPHIA ON PHONE Why not?

MICHAEL Because he heard me say your name. Donald knows about you, and I know about her. If I expose him, he exposes me.

SOPHIA ON PHONE *(quietly)* So we're both somebody's secret. *(beat)* Are you still angry I left on my birthday?

MICHAEL I'm angry I made you leave.

> *A soft silence on the line.*

SOPHIA ON PHONE That's the first nice thing you've ever said without a camera nearby.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 14 OF 30 · 10:18–10:52 SECRET

The Rules

INT. MICHAEL'S TRAILER — FILM SET — NIGHT

> *Michael paces. Sophia sits on the sofa, unimpressed.*

MICHAEL Tomorrow, Donald and Geoffrey are visiting the set. Investor visit. So for one day, we're not… whatever we are.

SOPHIA What are we pretending to be?

MICHAEL Enemies. You're the writer suing me. You hate me. Be cold. Be rude. Insult me if you have to.

SOPHIA *(a slow, dangerous smile)* Insult you?

MICHAEL …Not too much.

SOPHIA Michael, I've been rehearsing for this role since the day I met you.

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

Will the "enemies" act fool Donald and Geoffrey?

- ☐ Yes, they're completely fooled
- ☐ No, they see right through it

Revealed in Scene 15 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 15 OF 30 · 10:52–11:33 SECRET

The Worst Actor in Nigeria

EXT. THE LAST HORIZON SET — DAY

> *Donald and Geoffrey walk onto the set in suits, with Kola guiding them. Sophia is at the monitor. Michael meets them, too cheerful.*

MICHAEL Brothers! Welcome! This is… *(He gestures at Sophia stiffly.)* …that writer. The one suing us.

SOPHIA *(ice cold, not looking up)* Mr. McClaren. Your continuity is a disaster, your actors sound like adverts and your shirt is an insult to fabric.

DONALD *(eyebrows rising)* Ah.

MICHAEL *(overacting)* HOW DARE YOU, madam! *(He steps back dramatically, trips over a camera cable and nearly falls into the monitor.)* …I am FINE. Totally fine.

SOPHIA *(trying not to laugh)* You see? He can't even walk on his own set.

GEOFFREY *(quietly, to Donald)* He's never tripped on a set in fifteen years.

DONALD *(watching Michael closely)* No. He hasn't.

> *Sophia hands Michael a script page. Their fingers touch. He jumps as if it burned him.*

MICHAEL Thank you, Sophia, my lo— my… lawyer. My lawyer will contact you.

> *Long silence. Donald folds his arms.*

DONALD "Script Supervisor."

MICHAEL *(sweating)* Don't.

TWIST REVEALED · Will the “enemies” act fool Donald and Geoffrey? The answer: **No, they see right through it**. See what you guessed in Scene 14 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 16 OF 30 · 11:33–12:41 SECRET

The Brothers Explode

INT. MICHAEL'S TRAILER — MOMENTS LATER

Donald shuts the door. Geoffrey leans against the wall. The three brothers are crammed into a small trailer.

DONALD Your budget is six billion naira over, you've fired the biggest actor in Nigeria, the insurers are asking questions, and you're on set flirting with the woman who's SUING YOU?

MICHAEL I am not flirting!

DONALD You called her "my love."

MICHAEL I called her "my lawyer"!

DONALD You said "my lo—" and then you invented a lawyer!

MICHAEL *(exploding)* And YOU? You want to talk about rule four? Halbrook is bleeding money, you're hiding a size thirty-eight heel in your kitchen, and you've got the nerve to stand in my trailer and—

He stops himself. Too late. Donald goes very still.

GEOFFREY *(slowly)* What heel?

Donald and Michael look at each other. Silence.

DONALD *(cold)* Nothing. *(to Michael)* We'll discuss your budget in the boardroom. Like businessmen.

MICHAEL Like brothers, you mean? Oh no, we stopped doing that.

GEOFFREY *(opening the door)* I'm leaving before someone says something they can't take back.

MICHAEL You never say ANYTHING, Geoffrey! That's your whole personality!

Geoffrey stops in the doorway without turning around.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* Some of us are protecting more than a film, Michael.

He leaves. Donald follows. Michael kicks the trailer wall, hard.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 17 OF 30 · 12:41–13:05

The Email She Wasn't Supposed to See

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — MICHAEL'S OFFICE — 1 AM

Michael has given Sophia his laptop and password so she can finish the rewrites overnight while he's at the investor dinner. She's alone in the dark, typing. A new email notification slides in. It's FROM: Michael McClaren, TO: Investors, SUBJECT: The Writer.

SOPHIA *(reading aloud, her voice slowly dying)* "The writer is irrelevant. Once filming ends, the story belongs to the studio. Her name will be removed from the credits. Let her sue. She can't afford it." *(beat)* "— M."

She reads it again. Her hand covers her mouth. She looks at the photo of her father on her phone, then back at the screen.

SOPHIA *(through tears)* "Irrelevant."

Her jaw sets. She opens the studio's internal email folder labelled "LAST HORIZON — CHANGES", selects everything, attaches her original screenplay and types an address: gist@lagosgistqueen.ng.

Her finger hovers over SEND. A long pause.

SOPHIA You taught me this, Michael. Betray me once…

She presses SEND.

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

“The writer is irrelevant.” Who really sent that email?

- ☐ Michael
- ☐ Kola
- ☐ Mr. Hargreaves
- ☐ Sophia, to herself

Revealed in **Scene 26 →**

↑ All scenes

SCENE 18 OF 30 · 13:05–14:11

"Dead to Me"

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — MICHAEL'S OFFICE — THE NEXT NIGHT

> *We're back in Scene 1, continuing the moment. Rain, screens and the blogs.*

MICHAEL *(barely a whisper)* ...I don't know.

SOPHIA *(holding up her phone to show the email)* "The writer is irrelevant." Did you think I'd never see it?

MICHAEL *(reading it, confused)* I never wrote this.

SOPHIA It's from your account, Michael!

MICHAEL I was at the investor dinner! I didn't touch my phone all night! *(He slams the phone down.)* But YOU went through my laptop. My private files. I gave you my password, Sophia. I've never given ANYONE my password.

SOPHIA And I've never given anyone my father's story! You stole it first!

> *Kola enters with two security guards. His face is grave.*

KOLA Sir. Mr. Hargreaves has pulled the deal. Two other investors too. And Mr. Irwin is on line one. He's... shouting.

> *Michael looks at Sophia for a long, terrible moment. Then the ruthless director comes back. His voice goes flat and cold.*

MICHAEL Kola. Ban her from every McClaren set. Freeze her payments. Sue her for two billion naira.

SOPHIA *(stunned)* Michael—

MICHAEL You know my rule. *(He turns his back to her.)* Betray me once, and you're dead to me.

> *Security steps forward. Sophia walks out on her own and stops at the door.*

SOPHIA *(without turning around)* My father died at sea, Michael. You're dying on land. You just don't know it yet.

> *She's gone. Behind Michael's back, Kola allows himself the smallest smile.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 19 OF 30 · 14:11–14:31

He Can't Delete Her

INT. EDITING SUITE — 3 AM

Michael sits alone in the dark, watching footage of Sophia at the table read, laughing, crying over her father's scene and correcting him. His finger hovers over DELETE ALL.

KOLA *(in the doorway)* Delete it, sir. She's poison.

Michael doesn't move.

KOLA Sir, you've destroyed men for less. Chuka. Dapo. A hundred others. Delete her.

MICHAEL *(very quietly)* Leave me, Kola.

KOLA Sir—

MICHAEL *(roaring)* LEAVE ME!

Kola leaves. Michael presses PLAY again. On screen, Sophia says, "Every evening, my mother stood on the beach until the horizon swallowed the sun." He mouths the words along with her.

MICHAEL *(whispering to the screen)* Why can't I hate you?

↑ All scenes

SCENE 20 OF 30 · 14:31–15:13

"I Still Love Him"

INT. MAMA BENNETT'S HOUSE, BADAGRY — NIGHT

> *Sophia sits on the floor with her head in her mother's lap.*

SOPHIA I betrayed him, Mama. I sent the emails. I wanted to hurt him the way he hurt me.

MAMA BENNETT *(stroking her hair)* Hurt people throw stones, my daughter. Even good people.

SOPHIA He's suing me for two billion naira.

MAMA BENNETT And?

SOPHIA *(her voice cracking)* And I still love him. *(beat)* What kind of fool still loves the man who's destroying her?

MAMA BENNETT The same kind who stood on that beach every evening for twenty years, waiting for a boat. *(She smiles sadly.)* It runs in our family.

> *Sophia's phone buzzes. It's a news alert: "BREAKING: Confidential Last Horizon footage leaked online. Insurance cancelled. McClaren Studios in crisis."*

SOPHIA *(sitting up, confused)* Footage? I didn't send any footage.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 21 OF 30 · 15:13–15:57

The Sabotage Gets Worse

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — CONFERENCE ROOM — DAY

Chaos. Michael, Kola, Bisi and lawyers are all there. Screens show the leaked footage everywhere.

BISI The camera crane malfunctioned this morning, sir. It nearly fell on the crew.

KOLA And the leaked footage came from a login with Miss Bennett's credentials. There's also… *(He slides a paper across.)* …a transfer. Five million naira from a studio account, to a man named Femi Bennett. Her cousin.

MICHAEL *(staring at the paper)* She's banned. She has no access.

KOLA Her credentials do, sir. Maybe she had a partner. *(beat)* Sir, I'm sorry. She fooled all of us.

Michael picks up the paper. His hand is shaking.

MICHAEL *(to himself)* The emails, I understand. But the crane? People could have died.

KOLA Hurt women do crazy things, sir.

Michael looks up at Kola for a long beat. Something flickers, and then it's gone.

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

Who leaked the footage and sabotaged the crane?

- ☐ Sophia
- ☐ Femi, her cousin
- ☐ Kola
- ☐ Nobody, it was an accident

Revealed in **Scene 27 →**

↑ All scenes

SCENE 22 OF 30 · 15:57–17:01

3 A.m., in the Rain

EXT. MAMA BENNETT'S GATE, BADAGRY — 3 AM — RAIN

> *Michael stands at the gate, soaked, without an umbrella or a driver. Sophia opens the door and freezes.*

SOPHIA You came to serve me more court papers? At 3 a.m.?

MICHAEL Did you leak the footage? *(beat)* Did you touch the crane?

SOPHIA *(walking into the rain to face him)* No. I sent the emails. Only the emails. And I'm sorry. I'm sorry I did it. But I would NEVER put your crew in danger. Never.

> *He searches her face.*

MICHAEL I've destroyed people for less than what you did. I know exactly how to ruin you. I have the lawyers, the money, the blogs. *(His voice breaks.)* So why am I standing in the rain outside your mother's gate at 3 a.m.?

SOPHIA *(softly)* Because you're not the man you pretend to be.

MICHAEL I don't know how to forgive, Sophia. I've never done it. Not once. I don't even know what it feels like.

SOPHIA *(touching his wet face)* It feels like this. Like standing in the rain when you could be dry.

> *He kisses her desperately. Then he pulls away, shaking, and walks back to his car without a word. She stands in the rain, confused and heartbroken.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 23 OF 30 · 17:01–17:30 PART ONE LINK SECRET

"Not Now, Michael"

INT. EVERYS — BACKSTAGE — DAY — (PART ONE, SCENE 36)

> *Donald is pressed against the wall, wrecked. Emma has been kidnapped. Michael and Geoffrey are with him. Michael's phone buzzes with a message from "Script Supervisor": "Tonight, 8pm. Same restaurant. Last chance, Michael. If you don't come, I'm leaving Lagos."*

DONALD *(broken)* I love her. I broke the vow. Take my share. Just help me find her. Please.

MICHAEL *(grabbing his face)* You idiot. You think we didn't know?

GEOFFREY We protect each other. Whatever it costs.

> *Michael looks at his phone, then at Donald, then back at the phone.*

MICHAEL And Donald, since we're confessing, I also have to tell you—

GEOFFREY *(sharply)* Not now, Michael.

> *Michael closes his mouth. He looks at Sophia's message one last time, puts the phone away and grabs his car keys.*

MICHAEL *(to Donald)* My car. Let's go get her.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 24 OF 30 · 17:30–17:43

The Second Empty Chair

INT. THE SAME RESTAURANT, VICTORIA ISLAND — NIGHT

> *The same table and the same window. Sophia waits, without a red dress this time, just a travel bag under the table. 8:00. 9:00. 10:30. 11:45. The candle burns down to nothing.*

WAITER Madam, we're closing.

SOPHIA *(quietly)* I know. *(She stands and looks at the empty chair.)* He'll always choose something bigger than me.

> *She types on her phone: "Goodbye, Michael." Send. She leaves the chair empty and walks out with her bag.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 25 OF 30 · 17:43–18:33

"When Is It Me?"

EXT. MAMA BENNETT'S HOUSE, BADAGRY — DAWN

A taxi waits, loaded with bags. Michael's car screeches up. He jumps out still wearing last night's clothes, dirty and exhausted, with a cut on his hand.

MICHAEL Sophia! Wait! I couldn't come last night! My brother… Donald's… someone he loves was taken. We were in a railway yard in Ebute-Metta until 4 a.m.

SOPHIA *(turning, surprised, then softening)* Is she alright?

MICHAEL She's alive. She's safe.

SOPHIA *(quietly)* I'm glad. *(beat)* Then you did the right thing.

MICHAEL So you'll stay?

SOPHIA No.

MICHAEL *(stunned)* Sophia—

SOPHIA Last night it was your brother. And I understand. But before that it was the deal, before that the film, and before that the investors. And next time it will be your vow. *(beat)* There's always something bigger, Michael. When is it ME?

He has no answer. She gets into the taxi.

SOPHIA And you're still suing me for two billion naira.

The taxi drives away. Michael stands in the dust, alone.

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

Sophia has left. How will Michael win her back?

- ☐ A very expensive gift
- ☐ Destroying whoever framed her
- ☐ Confessing in front of everyone

Revealed in Scene 29 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 26 OF 30 · 18:33–19:33

"Someone Sitting Close to You"

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — MICHAEL'S OFFICE — DAY

> *Michael sits at his desk with Sophia's goodbye text open. Geoffrey enters quietly and closes the door.*

GEOFFREY I've been looking into your sabotage. Quietly. Like I do everything.

MICHAEL *(not looking up)* It's Sophia. Her credentials, her cousin, the transfer.

GEOFFREY Her credentials were copied from inside McClaren Studios. From a computer on this floor. *(He sets down a printout.)* The footage leaked from a studio terminal at a time when Sophia was in Badagry. I checked her phone records. She hasn't left her mother's house in a week.

> *Michael slowly looks up.*

GEOFFREY And the email she saw, "the writer is irrelevant"? It was sent from your account at 12:58 a.m. on the night of the investor dinner. *(beat)* Michael, you were sitting next to me at that dinner. Your phone was in your pocket the whole night. I watched it.

MICHAEL *(standing slowly)* Then who…

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* The leak isn't outside, Michael. *(He looks at the empty chair beside Michael's desk, the one Kola always sits in.)* It's someone sitting close to you.

TWIST REVEALED · "The writer is irrelevant." Who really sent that email? The answer: **Kola**. See what you guessed in Scene 17 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 27 OF 30 · 19:33–20:53

The Third Brother

INT. MCCLAREN STUDIOS — MICHAEL'S OFFICE — NIGHT

A trap. Michael sits casually. Kola enters with two coffees, just like every night for fifteen years.

MICHAEL Kola. The master copy of the film. The only one. I'm moving it to the vault at Geoffrey's bank tomorrow at 6 a.m. Nobody else knows.

KOLA Good idea, sir. Safer.

He leaves. A moment later, Geoffrey's laptop on the side table lights up: "Intercepted call — K. Badmus → V. Adekunle (Apex Studios)."

KOLA ON RECORDING Victor, the master moves at six. Get your people ready. And after this, McClaren is finished. You promised me my own studio.

Michael closes his eyes. Then he calls out quietly.

MICHAEL Kola. Come back in.

Kola returns and sees the laptop. His face drops.

MICHAEL Fifteen years. Enugu. The weddings. You carried my cameras when I couldn't afford a bus. *(His voice is shaking.)* Why?

KOLA *(bitter, all the politeness gone)* Fifteen years, and you never once put my name on a poster. "A Michael McClaren film." Always Michael. Victor offered me my own studio. My OWN name. *(beat)* You have two brothers already, Michael. Donald and Geoffrey. You never had room for a third.

Silence. That one landed.

MICHAEL You faked the email. You framed her. You let me destroy the woman I—

KOLA *(smirking)* You did that yourself, sir. I only gave you a reason. You were always so ready to believe people betray you.

Michael stands. Every ruthless instinct in him rises. He walks right up to Kola, fists clenched. Then he stops.

MICHAEL *(quietly)* The old Michael would spend five years ruining you. *(He opens the door. Two POLICE OFFICERS wait outside.)* But I've got somewhere more important to be.

TWIST REVEALED · Someone in Michael's circle can't be trusted. Who? The answer: **Kola, his producer of fifteen years.** See what you guessed in Scene 7 →

> **TWIST REVEALED** · Who leaked the footage and sabotaged the crane? The answer: **Kola**. See what you guessed in Scene 21 →

↑ All scenes

SCENE 28 OF 30 · 20:53–21:54 PART ONE LINK SECRET

The Last Lie on the Rooftop

EXT. AJEGUNLE ROOFTOP — ROOFTOP NIGHT — (PART ONE, SCENE 45)

> *Fairy lights. Donald has just confessed and handed over his piece of the certificate. Everyone is laughing. Emma waits by the stairs. Michael's phone buzzes with a message from "Script Supervisor ❤️": "Where are you? You promised you'd tell them tonight."*

MICHAEL *(raising his glass)* Well. One down. *(turning to Geoffrey)* Still sworn?

GEOFFREY *(pause)* …Still sworn.

MICHAEL *(too loud, his heart breaking as he says it)* STILL SWORN!

> *Under the table, he turns his phone off. Donald watches him over his glass and says nothing.*

> *LATER. Michael's apartment, 1 a.m. Sophia sits on his sofa in the dark. She's back, and his heart leaps.*

MICHAEL Sophia! You came back. The lawsuit's gone, I cancelled it, I've been trying to tell you—

SOPHIA *(quietly)* I know. Geoffrey called me. He told me about Kola. *(beat)* And then I waited for you to tell your brothers about me. Tonight. Like you promised.

MICHAEL I was going to. I swear. But Donald had just confessed, and everyone was laughing, and I—

SOPHIA You said "still sworn." *(Her eyes fill with tears.)* I forgave you for the lawsuit. I forgave you for my birthday. I even forgave you for my father's ending. But I can't keep being the woman you're ashamed to be seen with.

> *She puts his spare key on the table.*

SOPHIA You're a brilliant director, Michael. You've controlled every scene of your life. *(beat)* Except the one where you choose me.

> *She walks out. This time he doesn't chase her. He sits in the dark and looks at the framed piece of the old ₦3,000 certificate on his wall.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 29 OF 30 · 21:54–23:32

The Premiere

INT. LAGOS GRAND CINEMA — PREMIERE OF "THE LAST HORIZON" — NIGHT

Red carpet, flashing cameras and a packed hall of a thousand people. Donald and Emma sit in the front row, and Geoffrey sits beside them. In the very back row, half hidden, is Sophia, with Mama Bennett holding her hand tightly so she can't leave. Michael walks onto the stage. The crowd goes quiet.

MICHAEL Good evening. Tonight was supposed to be a story about a fisherman who comes home rich. That's the version I sold to the world. *(beat)* It was a lie.

Murmurs in the hall.

MICHAEL This film was written by Sophia Bennett. *(The screen behind him reads: "WRITTEN BY SOPHIA BENNETT.")* Her father went to sea and never came back. Every evening, her mother stood on the beach until the horizon swallowed the sun. I changed that ending because I thought sadness wouldn't sell. *(beat)* Tonight, you'll see the real ending.

In the back row, Mama Bennett squeezes Sophia's hand. Sophia is crying.

MICHAEL Sophia once betrayed me. And I was ready to destroy her for it, because that's who I was. A man who never forgave anybody. *(beat)* But I betrayed her first. I took her father's story and sold it, and I hid her like a secret because of a promise I made with my brothers on a rooftop in Ajegunle.

In the front row, Donald and Geoffrey slowly turn to look at each other.

MICHAEL So tonight, in front of a thousand people, two brothers and every camera in Lagos, I'm breaking that promise. *(He looks straight at the back row.)* I love Sophia Bennett. I've loved her since she sat in my chair and told me I was in her story. *(beat)* Sophia. You asked me, "When is it me?" *(His voice breaks.)* It's you. Tonight, it's you, in front of everyone.

Silence. Then a woman stands up in the back row. Every head and every camera turns. Sophia walks slowly down the long aisle and stops at the foot of the stage.

SOPHIA *(tears and a small smile)* You're late again, Mr. Director.

MICHAEL *(kneeling at the edge of the stage)* I know. But for once, I'm early for something that matters.

She reaches up. He takes her hand and helps her onto the stage, and they kiss in front of a thousand people. The hall explodes with applause. In the front row, Emma claps hardest. Donald laughs and shakes his head. Geoffrey takes off his glasses and wipes them, slowly.

DONALD *(to Geoffrey, over the noise)* Script Supervisor.

GEOFFREY *(almost smiling)* I've known for months.

TWIST REVEALED · Sophia has left. How will Michael win her back? The answer: **Confessing in front of everyone**. See what you guessed in Scene 25 →

GUESS THE TWIST · TICK ONE

Two brothers have confessed. Will Geoffrey confess too?

- ☐ Yes, no more secrets
- ☐ No, he says “Still sworn”

Revealed in **Scene 30 →**

↑ All scenes

SCENE 30 OF 30 · 23:32 — END

Two Down

EXT. AJEGUNLE ROOFTOP — NIGHT — ONE WEEK LATER

The three leather chairs and fairy lights. Michael stands before his brothers holding his framed piece of the old ₦3,000 certificate. Sophia and Emma sit on the steps, laughing and sharing suya.

MICHAEL By the rules of this rooftop. I, Michael McClaren, confess. I fell in love. I broke the vow. *(He places his piece on the table.)* And by the way, Donald, I found your woman's shoe first. I just want that on record.

DONALD *(laughing)* And I heard "Sophia" first.

MICHAEL *(serious now)* And brothers… no more secrets. Not about women, not about money, not about anything. My budget, my sabotage, my mistakes. Everything goes on the table. That's how we started, and that's how we finish.

DONALD *(putting his hand on Michael's shoulder)* Agreed. No more secrets.

They both turn to Geoffrey. He stands at the edge of the rooftop with his back to them, looking at the lights of Ikoyi, where his father's mansion still stands.

MICHAEL Geoffrey?

DONALD You heard him. No more secrets.

Long pause.

GEOFFREY *(without turning)* Still sworn.

MICHAEL Geoffrey…

GEOFFREY *(turning, forcing a calm smile)* I said, still sworn.

His phone buzzes. He glances at it, and for the first time in his life, Geoffrey Durose's hand trembles. Michael and Donald see it.

DONALD *(quietly)* Geoffrey. What's wrong?

Geoffrey answers the phone and puts it to his ear. A woman's voice comes through, calm and cold.

OLIVIA *ON PHONE* Mr. Durose. My name is Olivia Hart. My father died helping build the fortune you inherited. *(beat)* And I think your father killed him.

Geoffrey slowly lowers the phone. Michael and Donald stare at him.

MICHAEL Geoffrey. Who was that?

GEOFFREY *(barely a whisper)* …The end of my family.

THE SWORN BACHELORS. PART THREE: GEOFFREY × OLIVIA. "THE SECRET OF DUROSE."

END

> **TWIST REVEALED** · Two brothers have confessed. Will Geoffrey confess too? The answer: **No, he says "Still sworn"**. See what you guessed in Scene 29 →

↑ All scenes

Answer key

Scene 7 → revealed in Scene 27

Someone in Michael's circle can't be trusted. Who? **Kola, his producer of fifteen years.** Kola worked for Apex Studios. He faked the email, framed Sophia and sabotaged the film for a studio of his own.

Scene 10 → revealed in Scene 11

It's Sophia's birthday and she's waiting. Will Michael show up? **Yes, three hours late and talking about a deal.** He arrived at 11:15 p.m. shouting “Two hundred countries!” and didn't notice the birthday cake.

Scene 14 → revealed in Scene 15

Will the “enemies” act fool Donald and Geoffrey? **No, they see right through it.** Michael tripped over a cable and called her “my lo— my lawyer”. Donald just said: “Script Supervisor.”

Scene 17 → revealed in Scene 26

“The writer is irrelevant.” Who really sent that email? **Kola.** It was sent at 12:58 a.m. while Michael sat next to Geoffrey at dinner. Kola sent it from Michael's account.

Scene 21 → revealed in Scene 27

Who leaked the footage and sabotaged the crane? **Kola.** Kola copied Sophia's credentials and made the transfer to her cousin to frame her.

Scene 25 → revealed in Scene 29

Sophia has left. How will Michael win her back? **Confessing in front of everyone.** At the premiere he gave her the writing credit and her real ending, and broke the vow in front of a thousand people.

Scene 29 → revealed in Scene 30

Two brothers have confessed. Will Geoffrey confess too? **No, he says “Still sworn”.** Geoffrey said “Still sworn” and then took a call from Olivia Hart. Part Three begins.

Your detective score

Count your correct guesses. **0–2:** Kola fooled you too. **3–5:** sharp, like Sophia. **6–7:** you think like Geoffrey, so you will need it in Part Three.

Coming next: The Sworn Bachelors, Part Three: Geoffrey × Olivia, "The Secret of Durose".